

# Writing Systems in East and Southeast Asia

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based on Goddard Chapter 6

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# Overview

- 1 Introduction to Writing Systems
- 2 Types of Writing Systems
- 3 Phonographic Systems: Alphabetic
- 4 Phonographic Systems: Featural
- 5 Logographic Systems
- 6 Japanese: A Multiscript System
- 7 Vietnamese
- 8 Calligraphy

# Outline

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# Introduction to Writing Systems

- Language: Primarily spoken, but writing is a stable, visible form.
- Writing is integral to language culture.
- Study of writing systems reveals cultural history and linguistic insights.
- Two basic principles: logographic and phonographic.
- Logographic: Symbols represent words/morphemes.
- Phonographic: Symbols represent sounds (phonemes/syllables).

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# Types of Writing Systems

- Logographic Systems:
  - Symbols represent morphemes (e.g., Chinese, Hieroglyphics).
- Phonographic Systems:
  - Alphabetic (segmental): Symbols represent phonemes (e.g., Latin script).
  - Syllabic: Symbols represent syllables (e.g., Japanese kana).
  - Featural: Symbols represent phonetic features (e.g., Korean Hangul).
- Mixed Systems:
  - Combination of logographic and phonographic elements (e.g., Japanese).

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# Alphabetic Systems: Malay/Indonesian — Jawi

- Traditional Jawi script:

- Arabic origin.
- Right to left writing.

- Example:

(1) السلام عليكم *as-salām 'alaykum* “Peace be upon you.”

- Jawi (جاوي) is a shortening of الجزائر الجاوي, *Al-Jaza'ir Al-Jawi* “Java Archipelago”
- *Jawi* is often used to mean ‘Malay’, for example in *Bahasa Jawi* “Malay Language”
- Jawi has 31 original Arabic letters;
  - 6 new letters constructed to fit phonemes native to Malay: ca (چ < /tʃ/), nga (ڠ < /ŋ/), pa (ڤ < /p/), ga (ڬ < /g/), va (ڤ < /v/),
  - 1 additional phoneme used in foreign loanwords: nya (ڬ < /n/).

# Jawi Script Details

- Jawi script is highly stylized for brush writing.
- Letters change form based on their position in the word.
- Example of a Jawi phrase:  
(2) بالي جكرتا (Bali Jakarta) - Bali to Jakarta
- Usage has declined but still part of Malaysian education.
- Used in religious documents and decoration

وورما نيت بهاس

Wordnet Bahasa

# Alphabetic Systems: Malay/Indonesian — Rumi

- Introduced by colonial powers.
  - Malay spelling followed English
  - Indonesian spelling followed Dutch
- Standardized in 1972 for both Malaysia and Indonesia.
  - *di-buat* → *dibuat*, *di-rumah* → *di rumah*
  - *ch* and *tj* /tʃ/ → *c*: *ketjap/kechap* → *kecap*
  - *njonja/nyonya* → *nyonya*
  - *ke-barat<sup>2</sup>-an* → *kebarat-baratan* “westernized”

# Alphabetic Systems: Thai

- Derived from Old Khmer script.  
Derived from Mon, originally Indic
- No spaces between words; consonants represented by main letters, vowels by diacritics.
- Example:  
(3) สวัสดี (sawasdee) - Hello
- Complex relationship between letters and tones.

# Thai Tones and Consonant Classes

- Consonant letters divided into three classes: high, middle, and low.
- Tone determined by initial consonant, tone marks, and vowel length.
- Thai words with initial /kh/ (Smalley 1994: 184)

| <b>Thai Word</b> | <b>Meaning</b> | <b>Thai Word</b> | <b>Meaning</b>  |
|------------------|----------------|------------------|-----------------|
| ขา               | khǎa leg       | คา               | khaa embedded   |
| ข่า              | khàa galangal  | ค่า              | khâa cost       |
| ข้า              | khâa slave     | ค้า              | kháa trade      |
| ขาด              | khàat lack     | คาด              | khâat to strap  |
| ขัด              | khàt obstruct  | คัด              | khát be clogged |

- Complicated function of the initial consonant, diacritic and final consonant
- But generally deterministic
- Like most writing systems, sound changes quicker than writing

# Thai vowels

อะ

a

[a]

อ

a

[a]

อา

a

[a:]

อิ

i

[i]

อี

i

[i:]

อุ

ue

[u]

อุ

ue

[u:]

อู

ue

[u:]

อู

u

[u]

อู

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[u:]

เอะ

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[e]

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[ɛ]

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[ɛ]

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[o:]

เอาะ

o

[ɔ]

อัว

o

[ɔ]

อว

o

[ɔ:]

อ

o

[ɔ]

เอาะ

oe

[ɔ:]

เอา

oe

[ɔ:]

เอ

oe

[ɔ:]

# Thai diphthongs

|           |          |           |           |           |         |           |
|-----------|----------|-----------|-----------|-----------|---------|-----------|
| เียะ      | เีย      | เือะ      | เือ       | ัวะ       | ัว      | ว         |
| ia        | ia       | uea       | uea       | ua        | ua      | ua        |
| [iaʔ]     | [ia]     | [ueaʔ]    | [uea]     | [uaʔ]     | [ua]    | [ua]      |
| ิว        | เียว     | เวย       | เวย       | เวย       | าว      | เียว      |
| io        | eo       | eo        | aeo       | ao        | ao      | iao       |
| [iu/iw]   | [eu/ew]  | [e:u/e:w] | [ɛ:u/ɛ:w] | [au/aw]   | [a:u]   | [iau/iaw] |
| ้าย       | ไอ       | ไอ        | ไวย       | อาย       | อัย     | ออย       |
| ai        | ai       | ai        | ai        | ai        | oi      | oi        |
| [ai/aj]   | [ai/aj]  | [ai/aj]   | [ai/aj]   | [a:i/a:j] | [ɔi/ɔj] | [ɔ:i/ɔ:j] |
| ไอย       | อุย      | เอย       | อวย       | เือย      | อำ      | ฤ         |
| oi        | ui       | oei       | uai       | ueai      | am      | rue       |
| [o:i/o:j] | [ui/u:j] | [ɤ:i/ɤ:j] | [uai/uaj] | [uai/uaj] | [am]    | [ruu/ri]  |
| ฤา        | ร        | ร         | อ         | อ         |         |           |
| rue       | lue      | lue       | ʔ         | silences  |         |           |
| [ruu:]    | [luu]    | [luu:]    | [~]       | consonant |         |           |

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# Korean Hangul

한글

han

geul

7 L C 2 0 H 人 O 天 天

g n d r m b s -ng j ch

크 트 표 흥 | | | | |

k t p h a eo o u eu i

Image from Wikipedia (2024)

# Featural Systems: Korean Hangul

- Invented by King Sejong (15th century)
  - the process of invention is well documented in the Hunmin jeongeum, or “The correct sounds for the instruction of the people”
- Represents phonemes, arranged in syllable blocks.
- Example:
 

(4) 안녕하세요 *annyeonghaseyo* “hello”
- It was originally looked down on by scholars (who use hanzi) as used by women, children and the uneducated
- It was not widely adopted until the 19th century

# Korean Hangul: Design Principles

- Vowels represented by distinct vertical/horizontal strokes.
- Consonant shapes reflect place of articulation.
- One syllable is one block

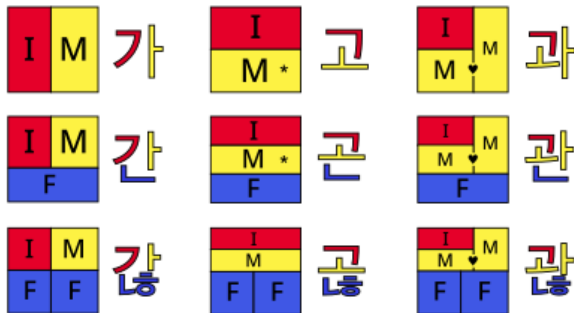
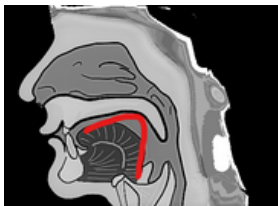


Image from Wikipedia (2024), cropped.

# Korean Consonants: shape $\approx$ articulation



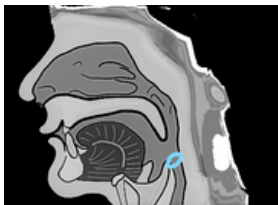
ㄱ /k/



ㄴ /n/



ㅅ /s/



ㅇ /ng/



ㅁ /m/

Images from Wikipedia (2024)

# Korean Consonants: shape $\approx$ articulation

|            | Basic | Simple | Aspirated            | Tense   |
|------------|-------|--------|----------------------|---------|
| Velar      |       | ㄱ (k)  | ㅋ (k <sup>h</sup> )  | 꺠 (k̚)  |
| Fricatives |       | ㅅ (s)  |                      | ㅆ (s̚)  |
| Palatal    |       | ㅈ (tɕ) | ㅊ (tɕ <sup>h</sup> ) | ㅉ (tɕ̚) |
| Coronal    | ㄴ (n) | ㄷ (t)  | ㅌ (t <sup>h</sup> )  | ㄸ (t̚)  |
| Bilabial   | ㅁ (m) | ㅂ (p)  | ㅍ (p <sup>h</sup> )  | ㅃ (p̚)  |
| Dorsal     | ㅇ (ʔ) | ㅇ (ŋ)  | ㅎ (h)                |         |

# Summary

- Hangul is a well-motivated alphabetic system, not a direct mapping of phonetic features
- Many sounds change in combination, so technically it is morphophonemic
- It is said that “A wise man can acquaint himself with them before the morning is over; even a stupid man can learn them in the space of ten days.”  
*Hunmin Jeongeum Haerye*, postface of Jeong Inji, p. 27a, translation from Gari K. Ledyard, *The Korean Language Reform of 1446*, p. 258

# Cia-Cia

- Cia-Cia (Bahasa Ciacia / 바하사찌아찌아) is a member of the Celebic branch of the Malayo-Polynesian language family (Austronesian)
- Spoken by about 80,000 people on Buton Island, a part of Indonesia to the south east of Sulawesi
- It used to be written in a Jawi-like script called Gundhul and is now mainly written in Rumi
- In 2007 Professor Chun Tai-hyun, a professor of Malay and Indonesian linguistics at Hankuk University of Foreign Studies in Seoul developed a Hangeul orthography
  - For fricative /v/ it uses the obsolete jamo **ㅍ** *kapyeounpieup* ‘light pieup’
- It was privately taught since 2009 using a textbook written by Lee Ho-young, a linguistics professor at Seoul National University.
- It was abandoned around 2012, and revived around 2022
- A Cia-Cia dictionary in Hangul was published in December 2021.
- Hangul remains in use in schools and on local signs

## Cia-cia being used



From Language of the Month November 2024 –Cia-Cia By L S, The National Museum of Language (online virtual museum)

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# Chinese Writing System

- Ancient origins, evolved from pictograms.
- Continually in use for over 3,000 years
- A powerful force for cultural and political unification
- Also adopted by surrounding languages (Japanese, Korean, Vietnamese)
- Characters mainly represent morphemes, often compound structures.
- Example:
  - (5) 你好 *nǐ hǎo* “hello ‘you good’ ”
  - (6) 山 *shān* “mountain”
- Reformed to simplified characters in the 1950s

# Development of Chinese character horse 马

| Type of Characters                                                                            | Descriptions                                                     |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 金文<br>文<br>  | Bronze script<br>Jin wen<br>15th - 11th centuries B.C.E.         |
| 甲骨文<br>文<br> | Oracle-bone script<br>Jia gu wen<br>12th - 11th centuries B.C.E. |
| 大篆<br>篆<br>  | Large-seal script<br>da chuan<br>c. 8th century B.C.E.           |
| 小篆<br>篆<br>  | Small-seal script<br>xiao chuan<br>2nd century B.C.E.            |
| 隸書<br>書<br>  | Clerical script<br>li shu<br>2nd century C.E.                    |
| 楷書<br>書<br>  | Standard script<br>k'ai shu<br>since c. 4th century C.E.         |
| 行書<br>書<br>  | Running script<br>Xing shu<br>since c. 4th century C.E.          |
| 草書<br>書<br>  | Cursive script<br>Chao shu<br>since c. 4th century C.E.          |

## Logograph writing system example: Chinese

## Pictographs

女 子 口 日 月 山 川 豕 目 心 雨 田 木 龜  
woman child mouth sun moon mountain river pig eye heart rain field tree turtle

## Ideographs

|     |     |       |       |       |        |                      |        |         |
|-----|-----|-------|-------|-------|--------|----------------------|--------|---------|
| 一   | 二   | 三     | 上     | 下     | 中      | 力                    | 凸      | 凹       |
| one | two | three | above | below | middle | strength<br>(plough) | convex | concave |

### Compound Pictographs / Compound Ideographs

|                 |                      |              |                    |                 |                    |                           |                    |
|-----------------|----------------------|--------------|--------------------|-----------------|--------------------|---------------------------|--------------------|
| 好               | 安                    | 明            | 家                  | 思               | 牢                  | 雷                         | 男                  |
| good            | peaceful             | bright       | home/family        | thought         | prison             | thunder                   | man/male           |
| (woman + child) | (woman under a roof) | (sun + moon) | (pig under a roof) | (heart + field) | (cow under a roof) | (rain cloud over a field) | (field + strength) |

# Semantic-phonetic compounds

## Semantic-phonetic compounds

phonetic component

|                              |                |              |                    |                  |            |
|------------------------------|----------------|--------------|--------------------|------------------|------------|
|                              | 古 gǔ           | 扁 biǎn       | 敖 áo               | 旁 páng           | 堯 yáo      |
| semantic component (radical) | 人 (person)     | 偏 piān       | 傲 ào               | 傍 bāng           | 僥 jiào     |
|                              | 言 (words)      | 諛 xiǎn       | 謗 wàng             | 謗 bàng           | 謗 náo      |
|                              | 虫 (insect)     | 蛄 gū         | 蝮 fù               | 螃 páng           | 蟯 xiào     |
|                              | 金 (metal)      | 鈷 gǔ         | 鋏 xié              | 鎊 bàng           | 鎊 náo      |
|                              | (to guess)     | (biased)     | (proud)            | (beside)         | (lucky)    |
|                              | (commentaries) | (to quibble) | (to slander)       | (to libel)       | (to argue) |
|                              | (mole cricket) | (bat)        | ([crab/s] nippers) | (crab)           | (worm)     |
|                              | (cobalt)       |              | (griddle)          | (pound sterling) | (cymbals)  |

97% of Chinese characters are phonetic compounds (Sproat 2010)! Other estimates are lower (Wang, pc 2013)

# Structure of Chinese Characters

- Phonetic component gives clues to pronunciation.
- Semantic radical provides meaning hints.
- Characters require memorization due to irregular phonetic-semantic correspondences.

# Using Chinese Characters for Non-Mandarin Chinese

- Chinese characters were designed for Mandarin, which poses challenges for other Sinitic languages.
- Problem: Phonetic clues in Mandarin characters often don't apply to languages like Cantonese and Taiwanese.
- For literacy in Cantonese or Taiwanese, familiarity with Mandarin's written form is often assumed.
- Despite differences, some words in Cantonese and Taiwanese can be represented with Mandarin characters.
- Issue: Many words and grammatical elements in other Sinitic languages lack standard Mandarin equivalents.

# Writing Strategies for Cantonese

- Cantonese writers use various strategies to adapt characters:
  - ➊ **Unique Cantonese Characters:** Characters created for words without Mandarin equivalents.
  - ➋ **Phonetic Resemblance:** Using Mandarin characters that sound similar to Cantonese words.
  - ➌ **English Letters:** Borrowing letters to represent Cantonese sounds.
- Example of phonetic adaptation: The Cantonese plural suffix **-deih** is represented by combining ‘mouth’ and ‘earth’ characters, resembling the pronunciation **deih**: 㗎

# Workarounds

(7) 你 喺 嗰度 好 喇, 千 祈 咪 搞 佢 啲  
 你 o 係 果度 好 la, 千 祈 咪 搞 佢 D

you being there good SFP, thousand pray don't mess with he/she of  
 嘢 o

野 o

things/stuff .

You'd better stay there, and under no circumstances mess with his/her stuff.

- use 'o' instead of 口
- use alphabet: 'D'
- use homophones: 果度 for 嗰度
- because Cantonese is mainly spoken, there is considerable variation in the orthography

# Loan words

Because of the influence of English, Cantonese tends to use more loan words (as does Singapore Mandarin). Note that speakers also freely use Mandarin vocabulary, ...

| Cantonese | Jyutping    | English  | Mandarin | Pinyin           |
|-----------|-------------|----------|----------|------------------|
| BB        | bi4 bi1     | baby     | 嬰兒       | ying1 er2        |
| 巴士        | baa1 si2    | bus      | 公交车      | gong1 jiao1 che1 |
| 拜拜        | baai1 baai3 | bye bye  | 再见       | zai4 jian4       |
| 沙展        | saa1 zin2   | sergeant | 排长       | pai2 zhang3      |

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# Japanese Writing System

- Combines kanji (logographic) and kana (syllabic).
- Example:

(8) こんにちは konnichiwa (hello)  
 山 yama (mountain)

# Syllabaries: Hiragana and Katakana

- Hiragana: Used for particles, auxiliary verbs, and suffixes.
  - Derived from cursive versions of kanji with suitable pronunciation
- Katakana: Used for loanwords, mimetics, and emphasis.
  - Derived from components of kanji with suitable pronunciation

## Hiragana - a true syllabic alphabet

## 平仮名 (ひらがな) hiragana

|    |   |   |     |   |   |     |   |   |    |   |   |    |   |   |
|----|---|---|-----|---|---|-----|---|---|----|---|---|----|---|---|
| a  | あ | 安 | i   | い | 以 | u   | う | 宇 | e  | え | 衣 | o  | お | 於 |
| ka | か | 加 | ki  | き | 幾 | ku  | く | 久 | ke | け | 計 | ko | こ | 己 |
| sa | さ | 左 | shi | し | 之 | su  | す | 寸 | se | せ | 世 | so | そ | 曾 |
| ta | た | 太 | chi | ち | 知 | tsu | つ | 川 | te | て | 天 | to | と | 止 |
| na | な | 奈 | ni  | に | 仁 | nu  | ぬ | 奴 | ne | ね | 祢 | no | の | 乃 |
| ha | は | 波 | hi  | ひ | 比 | fu  | ふ | 不 | he | へ | 部 | ho | ほ | 保 |
| ma | ま | 末 | mi  | み | 美 | mu  | む | 武 | me | め | 女 | mo | も | 毛 |
| ya | や | 也 |     |   |   | yu  | ゆ | 由 |    |   |   | yo | よ | 与 |
| ra | ら | 良 | ri  | り | 利 | ru  | る | 留 | re | れ | 礼 | ro | ろ | 呂 |
| wa | わ | 和 | wi  | ゐ | 為 |     |   |   | we | ゑ | 恵 | wo | を | 遠 |
|    |   |   |     |   |   |     |   |   |    |   |   | n  | ん | 无 |

## Katakana - a true syllabic alphabet

## 片仮名 (カタカナ) katakana

|    |   |   |     |   |   |     |   |   |    |   |   |    |   |   |
|----|---|---|-----|---|---|-----|---|---|----|---|---|----|---|---|
| a  | ア | 阿 | i   | イ | 伊 | u   | ウ | 宇 | e  | エ | 江 | o  | オ | 於 |
| ka | カ | 加 | ki  | キ | 幾 | ku  | ク | 久 | ke | ケ | 介 | ko | コ | 己 |
| sa | サ | 散 | shi | シ | 之 | su  | ス | 須 | se | セ | 世 | so | ソ | 曾 |
| ta | タ | 多 | chi | チ | 千 | tsu | ツ | 川 | te | テ | 天 | to | ト | 止 |
| na | ナ | 奈 | ni  | ニ | 二 | nu  | ヌ | 奴 | ne | ネ | 祢 | no | ノ | 乃 |
| ha | ハ | 八 | hi  | ヒ | 比 | fu  | フ | 不 | he | ヘ | 部 | ho | ホ | 保 |
| ma | マ | 万 | mi  | ミ | ミ | mu  | ム | 牟 | me | メ | 女 | mo | モ | 毛 |
| ya | ヤ | 也 |     |   |   | yu  | ユ | 由 |    |   |   | yo | ヨ | 與 |
| ra | ラ | 良 | ri  | リ | 利 | ru  | ル | 流 | re | レ | 礼 | ro | ロ | 呂 |
| wa | ワ | 和 | wi  | ヰ | 井 |     |   |   | we | エ | 恵 | wo | ヲ | 乎 |
|    |   |   |     |   |   |     |   |   |    |   |   | n  | ン | 无 |

# Extending Hiragana and Katakana

- **Dakuon** (濁音: 〃): voicing
  - か (ka) → が (ga);
  - さ (sa) → ざ (za);
  - た (ta) → だ (da);
  - ハ (ha) → バ (ba)
- **Handakuten** (半濁点: °) plosive
  - は (ha) → ぱ (pa)
- **Yōon** (拗音): palatalized
  - Consonant + 'i' combines with small “ya,” “yu,” or “yo” (や, ゆ, よ).
    - き (ki) + や (xya) → きゃ (kya);
    - し (shi) + よ (xyo) → しょ (sho); ...
- **GōYōon** (合拗音): labialized (now only in Okinawan)
  - くわ (kwa),    くゐ (kwi), くゑ (kwe),    くを (kwo)
- **Sokuon** (促音):
  - Small つ marks a geminate consonant normally transliterated by doubling さっか *sakka*

# Kanji and Mixed System Writing

- Lexical roots written in kanji.
- Grammatical elements in hiragana.
- Foreign words in katakana (or romaji).
- Mixed system allows nuanced text creation.

(9) 彼女は Tシャツを 着.ている  
 kanojo ha T sha-tu wo ki te iru  
 she TOP T shirt ACC wear PRG  
 She is wearing a T-shirt

# Homophones and Context Dependence

- Japanese has many homophones due to the limited set of sounds in the language.
- Kanji helps distinguish words with the same pronunciation but different meanings, yet:
  - Words with identical readings may use different kanji.
  - Context often determines which kanji is appropriate, adding complexity.
- Example: こうしょう (kōshō) can mean “negotiation” (交渉) or “factory” (鋳床), depending on kanji and context. (WWWDIC has 44 possible entries)

# Why Kanji Have Multiple Readings

- Kanji have multiple readings due to their integration from Chinese into Japanese over centuries.
- Japanese and Chinese are linguistically different, so adaptations were necessary.
- Kanji readings can be divided into two main types:
  - **On'yomi** (音読み): Chinese-derived readings.
  - **Kun'yomi** (訓読み): Native Japanese readings.
- This dual system has led to multiple ways of reading kanji, depending on context.

# Historical Borrowing from Chinese

- Kanji were imported from China starting in the 5th century, with Chinese pronunciations.
- **On'yomi** (音読み) readings were derived from Chinese pronunciations.
- Different periods and regions of Chinese influence led to varied on'yomi.
- For example, 山 has the reading **さん** (“san”) in compounds, like in 火山 (“kazan,” meaning “volcano”).
- The Chinese-derived readings are often used in compound words.

# Native Japanese Words (Kun'yomi)

- Many kanji represented concepts that already had native Japanese words.
- To adapt, kanji were assigned **kun'yomi** (訓読み), or native Japanese readings.
- Example: 明 can be read as あか in the native Japanese word 明るい *akarui* “bright”.
- Kun'yomi is often used when kanji stand alone or in names.
- This creates another layer of readings that are essential for native vocabulary.
- Many characters also have readings normally only used in names **nanori** (名乗り)

# Multiple Chinese Influences: Go-on, Kan-on, Tō-on

- Kanji were imported from China starting in the 5th century, with Chinese pronunciations.
- **On'yomi** (音読み) readings were derived from Chinese pronunciations.
- Kanji were borrowed in waves, reflecting different Chinese dynasties and regions:
  - **Go-on** (呉音): Earlier readings from the Wu region.
  - **Kan-on** (漢音): Pronunciations from the Tang Dynasty.
  - **Tō-on** (唐音): Later readings from the Song and Ming Dynasties.
- Some kanji have multiple on'yomi due to these varied influences, used in different contexts.
- Example: 明 has readings like めい ("mei") and みょう ("myō") based on context.

# 明

According to Kanjidic this character has the following readings:

- ON: メイミョウミン
- KUN: あ.かりあか.るいあか.るむあか.らむあき.らかあ.ける -あ.け  
あ.くあ.くるあ.かす
- Names: あきらあけあすきらけさやさやかとしはるみめ

<https://www.edrdg.org/cgi-bin/wwwjdic/wwwjdic?1B>

Chinese and Korean have one reading each *ming2* and *myeong*

# Character Complexity and Memory Load

- Japanese kanji characters are often complex and require memorization of many details:
  - A standard-educated adult in Japan knows about 2,000 kanji.
  - Each kanji has multiple readings (pronunciations), which change based on context and word combinations.
- Learning kanji is time-intensive, requiring years of study.
- Even native speakers may struggle with less common kanji or readings, leading to a heavy memory load.

# Historical Reforms and Modern Challenges

- Orthographic reforms have been implemented to simplify kanji, but challenges remain:
  - The **Tōyō Kanji** reform (1946) and **Jōyō Kanji** list (1981) aimed to standardize kanji usage.
  - However, non-standard or rare kanji still appear in literature and names, requiring additional study.
- Modern technology poses new issues:
  - Typing kanji requires selecting the correct character from multiple homophones.
  - Many younger people may rely on digital aids, impacting kanji writing skills.
- Japanese orthography is still a challenging system to master.

# Outline

- 1 Introduction to Writing Systems
- 2 Types of Writing Systems
- 3 Phonographic Systems: Alphabetic
- 4 Phonographic Systems: Featural
- 5 Logographic Systems
- 6 Japanese: A Multiscript System
- 7 Vietnamese**
- 8 Calligraphy

# Writing in Vietnam

- Vietnamese today uses the Latin script-based Vietnamese alphabet to represent native Vietnamese words (thuần Việt)
- From 111 BC up to the 20th century, Vietnamese literature was written in Văn ngôn (Classical Chinese) using chữ Hán (Chinese characters)
- From the 13th century to 20th century it could also be written in Nôm (Chinese and original Vietnamese characters adapted for vernacular Vietnamese)
- From the 17th century Portuguese missionaries developed a script based on Portuguese, which was mainly used within the Catholic community. During the French administration, the alphabet was further modified and then later made a part of compulsory education in 1910

# Thuần Việt

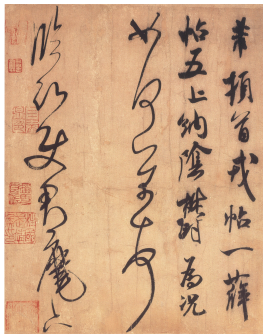
- 29 letters: 7 letters use diacritics: <ă>, <â>, <ê>, <ô>, <ơ>, <ư>, and <đ>
- An additional 5 diacritics used to designate tone (as in <à>, <á>, <ả>, <ã>, and <ạ>), level tone is unmarked.
- Diacritics stack, e.g. *nhất* “first”
- Sound changes in the spoken language have led to different letters, digraphs and trigraphs now representing the same sounds.
  - Northern dialect has 6 tones
  - Southern dialect has merged <à> *hỏi* and <ã> *ngã* to just <ả> *hỏi*.

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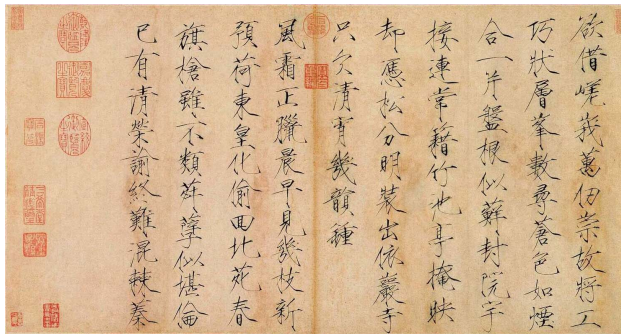
# Calligraphy in East Asia

- Highly valued art form, more esteemed than painting.
- Reflects cultural aesthetics and individuality.
- Styles include Seal Script, Clerical Script, Standard Script, Running Script, and Grass Script.
- Chinese calligraphy emphasizes brush techniques and stroke order.



Mi Fu (1051–1107)

Francis Bond



Emperor Huizong of Song (1082–1135)

Writing Systems in East and Southeast Asia

2026

## Japanese Calligraphy

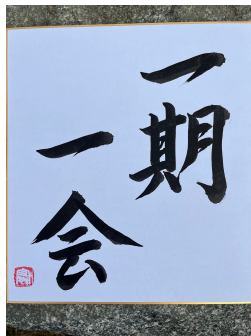
- Emphasis on the beauty of handwriting.
- Grass style and Zen calligraphy notable for their fluidity and abstraction.



別無工夫

*betsu-naku kuufuu*

nothing else but focus



一期一会

*ichi-go ichi-e*

one lifetime one chance

# Indonesian Calligraphy

- Jawi calligraphy is based on Arabic calligraphy
- Often very ornate



# Arabic calligraphy in Diwani style



يَا أَيُّهَا النَّبِيُّ إِنَّا أَرْسَلْنَاكَ شَاهِدًا وَمُبَشِّرًا وَنَذِيرًا وَدَاعِيًا إِلَى اللَّهِ

“O Prophet, indeed We have sent you as a witness and a bringer of good tidings and a warner, and as one who invites to Allah.”

Mehmet Izzet al-Karkuki (1841-1904)

Diwani is a calligraphic variety of Arabic script, developed during the reign of the early Ottoman Turks (16th century - early 17th century).

# Summary

- There are many, many different scripts, with adaptations and borrowings
- It is very hard to change a nation's script although it does happen
  - Most countries have abandoned or limited the use of Chinese Characters
  - But having to learn a new script and reprint everything is a massive undertaking, ...

# Acknowledgements

- Images taken from Omniglot (<https://omniglot.com/>) unless otherwise stated